ROMAN ARMOUR

The Roman legionary's armour was a compromise between protection and mobility. Head, shoulders, and torso were well protected by the iron helmet and cuirass, but arms and legs were uncovered. It is thought, however, that soldiers sometimes wore greaves to protect their legs and even flexible arm guards of overlapping plates. Although there was considerable uniformity in the appearance of the legions across the empire, especially in the 1st century CE, legions must often have been kitted out in a variety of different styles of armour and helmets.

> "THE YOUNG SOLDIER MUST BE GIVEN FREQUENT PRACTICE IN CARRYING LOADS OF UP TO 60 POUNDS WHILE MARCHING AT NORMAL SPEEDS."
>
> **VEGETIUS**, *A MILITARY DIGEST*, 4TH CENTURY CE

Helmet
A widely used model of the late 1st century CE, the design of the helmet was based originally on Gallic styles. It gave good protection to the legionary's cheeks and to the back of his neck. Helmets were fitted with the means of attaching a crest, but it seems that the ordinary legionary did not wear one in battle, so they were perhaps a feature of ceremonial parades.

Fitting for attaching crest

Projecting ridge giving added protection from downward sword blows

Cheek guard

Large sloping neck guard for extra protection

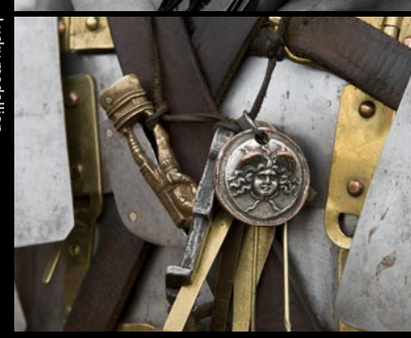
Brass fittings

Iron plates, articulated by means of internal leather straps

Brass fastenings tied with leather thongs



Securing the cheek guards



Lucky medallion hanging round neck